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# ARTICLES

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# ARTICLES

## DEFINITE AND INDEFINITE ARTICLES

There are three articles: ***a***, ***an***, and ***the***.

# ARTICLES

## DEFINITE AND INDEFINITE ARTICLES

There are three articles: *a*, *an*, and *the*.

Articles are used before nouns or noun equivalents and are a type of adjective.

- He is a great leader.
- He is an extraordinary leader.
- He is the leader of the rebels.

# ARTICLES

## DEFINITE ARTICLE

- The definite article (*the*) is used before a noun to indicate that the identity of the noun is known to the reader/listener. It is used before a noun that is 'defined' or made specific.
- These days, **women** are actively joining politics.
- **Women** have the advantage of reservation.
- **The women who win elections** do better than men.

# ARTICLES

## INDEFINITE ARTICLES

- The indefinite article (*a, an*) is used before a noun that is **general** or when its **identity is *not* known** to the speaker or writer.
- There is *a* boy waiting outside.
- There is *an* elephant in your garden.

- Here is **an** apple for you. This is from **the** orchard we visited yesterday.
- This is from **the** orchard we visited yesterday.
- This apple is from ..... orchard.
- This is from one of the orchards that we visited yesterday.

# ARTICLES

## INDEFINITE ARTICLES

**Specific identity not known:**

- Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound
- Use **an** before nouns that begin with a vowel sound.

Remember, English is non-phonetic

**GHOTI**



**GHOTI = FISH**

- Rou**gh** = **F**
- W**o**men = **I**
- Situa**ti**on = **SH**

# INDEFINITE ARTICLE - **an**

Use **an** before nouns that begin with a vowel sound.

- an **a**pricot.
- an **e**gg.
- an **i**diot.
- an **o**rbital.
- an **u**prising.

# INDEFINITE ARTICLE - **a**

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

- a **t**able
- a **ch**air
- a **p**en
- a **w**atch
- a **b**ook

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

## a vs. an

“**a** history book” (because history begins with a consonant sound).

**Vs.**

“**an** (h)our” (because hour begins with a vowel sound)

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

“**a** **u**nion” even though ***u**nion* begins with a “**u**.”

(The pronunciation begins with “**y****u**”, which is a consonant sound.)

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

- a universal technique
- a university
- a one track mind - one-track starts with a W sound.
- an honour - the h is silent; (h)onour.  
a historic day - the h is pronounced.

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

- **a** unicorn Vs. **an** umbrella
- **a** Utopian idea Vs. **an** unfair world
- **an** MBA (em) Vs. **a** missionary

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

- An (h)our.
- An (h)onorary degree.
- An (h)eir.
- An (h)eirloom.
- An (h)erb (Am.).
- An (h)ors d'oeuvre. (*or-Derv*)



# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

- A hysterectomy (removing the uterus)
- A hereditary trait.
- A humble man.

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

- A young man
- A user
- A unicycle with an unusual problem
- A year
- An ear

He lost **a year** in college, because of **an ear** problem.

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound

- An NBC television show.
- An HTML document.
- An MS-DOS programme. (**E**M – S)
- An hourglass
- **A** CBS news outlet.
- **A** Microsoft programme. (**M**ycro)
- **A** one-eyed pirate

# INDEFINITE ARTICLES

Use **a** before nouns that begin with a consonant sound (**yu**)

- a European trip
- a uniform

BUT **an** before vowel sound

- an understanding person
- an unconventional strategy
- an Uber taxi

With 'a/an'

In the sense of one.

- He couldn't speak a word to save himself.

With 'a/an'

With units and rate (per):

- He earns rupees five hundred a month.
- Rice sells ten rupees a kilo.
- Give me a metre length of the cloth.

## With 'a/an'

In exclamatory expressions before singular countable nouns:

- What a handsome guy!
- How sunny a day!

## With 'a/an'

When two subjects or articles are thought of as a single unit.

- He was ready with a cup and saucer.
- A cigarette is made of a paper and tobacco.



## With 'a/an'

With a person's name to indicate that the person is perhaps unknown to the person addressed:

- A Mr. Roy is at the door.

With 'a/an'

**With certain expressions of quantity:**

- A lot of, a dozen, a great deal of, a couple.

## With 'a/an'

With a special meal (to celebrate something or in someone's honour.)

- I called my friends to a lunch to celebrate my success.
- A dinner was arranged to welcome the principal.

*BUT*

- Dinner is ready

## With 'a/an'

To make a common noun of a proper noun.

- This man is **a** second Newton.

*This phrase means 'a philosopher as great as Newton.'*

- **A** Daniel come to judgement.

*The phrase means 'a wise man'.*

## BUT with 'the'

When you use a famous name as a metaphor for a quality; it should also be specified.

- Ahmedabad is **the** Manchester of India.
- He is **the** Newton of our class.

## With 'the'

Use "the" when a noun has been mentioned before

*A cleaner went to **a** house. **The** cleaner was from **an** agency. **The** agency was run by **a** Charitable Trust. **The** Trust was founded by **a** politician. **The** politician.....*

## With 'the'

Use "the" when a noun is made specific by a following phrase.

“This is **the** book that I was looking for.”

(The clause "that I was looking for" makes the book specific).

NO ARTICLES

Continents

*Africa, Asia, Europe*



NO ARTICLES

Most of the Countries

*India, Ghana, Peru, Denmark, Italy, Mexico,  
Bolivia*

## WITH 'the'

Exceptions – Countries beginning with  
'United'

*the United Arab Emirates, the United Kingdom, the United States of America*

- He is going to the UK and he is planning to study in England

## With 'the'

Countries whose names include words like **Kingdom, States, Republic** or **Emirates**

- ***the** United Kingdom*
- ***the** Kingdom of Nepal*
- ***the** USA (United States of America)*
- ***the** People's Republic of China*
- ***the** UAE (United Arab Emirates)*

# WITH 'the'

## Some Exceptions - Countries

- *the Gambia*
- *the Dominican Republic*

## With 'the'

### Countries which have plural nouns as their names

- **the** Netherlands (*not an island nation, but it holds sovereignty over several Caribbean islands.*)
- **the** Philippines
- **the** Bahamas

NO ARTICLES

Islands

Easter Island, Maui, Key West

WITH 'the'

## Exceptions – Island Chains

- **the** Aleutians
- **the** Hebrides
- **the** Canary Islands
- **the** West Indies
- the Lakshadweep
- the Andamans .....

NO ARTICLES

Lakes

*Lake Victoria, Lake Superior, Lake Tanganyika*



WITH 'the'

Exceptions – A group of lakes

*the Great Lakes*

NO ARTICLES

Mountains

*Mount Everest, Mount Kilimanjaro, Mount Elbrus*

WITH 'the'

## Mountain Ranges

***the Andes, the Rockies, the Himalayas,  
the Alps***

or unusual names like ***the Matterhorn***

NO ARTICLES

Universities

*Cardiff University, Harvard University,  
Manchester University*

With 'the'

## Universities with 'of' in the title

- ***the** University of Cape Town, **the** University of Delhi, **the** University of Tokyo*

NO ARTICLES

## Names of languages

*Chinese, English, Spanish, Russian, Hindi,  
Malayalam,....*

## WITH 'the'

### When language represents people

When referring to the population/people of the nation:

"**The Spanish** are known for their warm hospitality."

"**The English** are generally very arrogant."

(Remember, it does not apply to all languages.)

With 'the'

## Seas and Oceans

- *the Atlantic*
- *the Pacific*
- *the Mediterranean*
- *The Bay of Bengal*
- *the Arabian Sea*



# With 'the'

## Rivers

- *the Nile*
- *the Amazon*
- *the Yangtze*
- *the Meenachil*

- The Meenachil..... (flood)???
- The Meenachil....(overflow)???
- Meenachil....

**The Meenachil (*river*) overflowed and  
Meenachil (*land*) was flooded.**

With 'the'

## Geographical Areas

- *the Middle East*
- *the West*

With 'the'

## Points on the Globe

- ***the** Equator*
- ***the** North Pole...*

# With 'the'

## Deserts, Gulfs, Forests, and Peninsulas

- ***the** Sahara*
- ***the** Persian Gulf*
- ***the** Black Forest*
- ***the** Iberian Peninsula*

With 'the'

# Hotels, Pubs and Restaurants

- *the Ritz*
- *the Taj*
- *the King's Head*

**NO 'the'** if it's the name of the OWNER

## Hotels, Pubs and Restaurants

- Brown's
- Brown's Hotel
- Morel's Restaurant



With 'the'

## Famous Families

- ***the Gandhis***
- ***the Tatas***
- ***the Obamas***
- ***the Trumps***

With 'the'

## Unique Positions / Titles

- The President
- The Prime Minister (when the title is used without the name).

*Example:* The President of India.

(*But:* President Murmu — No article when the name follows the title).

With 'the'

## Degrees and Numbers

- Superlatives: “He is **the best** student.”
- Ordinals: “Focus on **the first** chapter.”
- Parallel Comparison:

*Structure:* The + comparative ... the + comparative.

*Example:* **The** more you earn, **the** more you spend.

# With 'the'

## Organizations

- ***the** Seamen's Union*
- ***the** United Nations*
- ***the** UN (U. N.)*

***BUT***

*He joined 'UNESCO'*

With 'the'

Well known buildings and works of art

- ***the** Empire State Building*
- ***the** Taj Mahal*
- ***the** Mona Lisa*
- ***the** Sunflowers*

# With 'the'

## Newspapers

- ***the Times of India***
- ***the Hindu***
- ***the Washington Post***
- ***the Indian Express***

# With 'the'

## Holy Books

- *the Bible*
- *the Gita*
- *the Quran*

With 'the'

## Rivers, Seas and Oceans

- ***the Amazon***
- ***the Arabian Sea***
- ***the Atlantic Ocean***



With 'the'

## Canals and Deserts

- ***the Panama Canal***
- ***the Suez Canal***
- ***the Thar Desert***

With 'the'

With Collective Adjectives denoting  
Groups of People

- ***the rich***
- ***the poor***
- ***the elderly***

With 'the'

If there is only ONE

- ***the Pope***
- ***the Moon***
- ***the Shah of Iran***

With 'the'

## with Superlative Adjectives

- ***the** tallest girl*
- ***the** oldest building*
- ***the** smartest boy???* (*One of the smartest boys...*)

With 'the'

Because there is only ONE in that place  
or in those surroundings

- *We live in a small village, next to **the** church.*

*Vs*

- *We live in a city, next to **a** church.*

## With 'the'

Because there is only ONE in that place  
or in those surroundings

- *Uncle, can I borrow **the** car.*

*Vs*

- *Uncle, can I borrow **a** car.*

With 'the'

To refer to a system or service

- *How long does it take on **the train**?*  
*(Railway system) – rare usage!*
- *I heard it on **the radio**.*
- *You should tell **the police**.*

With 'the'

Musical instruments, in a general way

- *John plays **the piano** well.*
- *She is learning **the guitar**.*



## With 'the'

To say something about 'all the things' referred to by a noun (animals, plants etc.)

- ***The wolf** is not really a dangerous animal.*
- ***The kangaroo** is found only in Australia.*
- ***The heart** pumps blood around the body.*

# With 'the'

'the' comes after **all/both**

- All **the** boys....
- Both **the** friends....

# NO ARTICLES

## States, Cities and Towns

- *Karnataka*
- *Kerala*
- *Addis Ababa*
- *Hanoi*
- *New York*
- *Moscow*
- *Pala*

NO ARTICLES

## Names of Streets

- *Washington Blvd.*
- *Main St.*
- *Park Street*

# NO ARTICLES

## Names of sports

- *volleyball*
- *hockey*
- *Baseball...*

# NO ARTICLES

## Names of academic subjects

*Mathematics, Biology, History,  
Computer Science, Economics*

- *He teaches **M**athematics.*

*Vs*

- *He said that **the m**athematics of .....*
- ***The e**conomics of Kerala Model....*

No article

No article before the post following  
"Rank of/Job of".

- He was promoted to the rank of **General**.
- He was given the job of **Manager**.

# No Article

There are certain situations in which a noun takes no article.

- Boys are smart; girls are smarter.



**DOG / A DOG / THE DOG**

# A dog is a friendly animal

- Uses the indefinite article "a" to generalize about dogs as a category. This structure is common in everyday speech and emphasizes individual members of the group.
- Example: "A dog needs love and care."

# The dog is a friendly animal

- Uses the definite article "the" to refer to the entire species as a collective concept. This is more formal and often used in scientific, academic, or literary contexts.
- Example: "The dog evolved alongside humans."

# Dogs are friendly

- Use plural nouns with zero article (most common for generalizations)
- → Dogs are loyal.
- → Elephants have long trunks.

# Which to choose?

- Casual/General Statements: Use "a dog."
- Formal/Generalisations About the Species: Use "the dog."
- Both are correct, but "a dog" is more natural for everyday use. If you're unsure, default to "a dog" or use the plural ("Dogs are friendly animals") for simplicity.

# NO ARTICLES

## **Certain nonfood substances (in general):**

air, cement, coal, dirt, gasoline, gold, paper,  
petroleum, plastic, rain, silver, snow, soap,

# NO INDEFINITE ARTICLES

## **Certain food and drink items (in general):**

bacon, beef, bread, broccoli, butter, cabbage, candy, cauliflower, celery, cereal, cheese, chicken, chocolate, coffee, corn, cream, fish, flour, fruit, ice cream, lettuce, meat, milk, oil, pasta, rice, salt, spinach, sugar, tea, water, wine, yogurt.....

# Let's Revise

- *I do not want **a** gun in my house* (any gun).
- ***The** gun is in his closet* (implies there is a specific gun).
- *I am afraid of guns* (all guns in general).



# Let's Revise

- *She sent me **a** postcard from Italy* (an unspecific postcard - not a letter, not an e-mail).
- *It's **the** postcard that I have in my office* (one specific postcard).
- *Getting postcards makes me want to travel* (any postcard in general).

# Let's Revise

- *I have **a dog*** (one dog).
- ***The dog** is very friendly* (the dog that I have already mentioned).
- ***Dogs** make great pets* (dogs in general).

# Let's Revise

- *Greta needs furniture in her apartment* (furniture is a noncount noun).
- *She is going to select **the** furniture that she needs* (the specific furniture that she needs).
- *She hopes to find **some** furniture this weekend* (an unspecified, limited amount of furniture).

# Let's Revise

- *We are going to see **the** Statue of Liberty this weekend* (the only Statue of Liberty).